W. Gertrude Brown: A Case of Black Women's Activism in Minnesota, 1920-1940

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INTRODUCTION

- This study seeks to understand the arc of W. Gertrude Brown's influence as an activist and a community leader during her years as the Head Resident of the Phyllis Wheatley House.
- By identifying Brown as a change agent in Minnesota, the dynamics on Black women's activism in Minnesota will be explored.
- Engaging in local historical research with a critical lens for Black feminist historiography, African-American women's history, and Black public sphere theory to identify core elements of Brown's activism that speak to the history of Black women's activism nationally.
- This research is the genesis of a larger study of Black women's activism in Minnesota.

BACKGROUND

- The Phyllis Wheatley House was founded on October 17, 1924 as a settlement house created by the Women's Christian Association (WCA) and funded by the Community Chest Fund, with the goal of serving the African-American community in Minneapolis and St. Paul.
- Miss. W. Gertrude Brown, a Dayton, Ohio social worker, was its first Head Resident for thirteen years until late 1937.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

- How did W. Gertrude Brown utilize her position as Head Resident, in partnership with her past professional affiliations and networks, to cement the Phyllis Wheatley House as a crucial institution in the Black community in Minnesota during the early 20th century?
- What notable strategies, activities, and networks did she embrace that align with examples of Black women's activism both nationally and internationally during the post-emancipation era?

CRITICAL LITERATURE REVIEW

Black Feminist Historiography

- Evelyn Brooks Higginbotham's *Righteous Discontent* (1993) and Bettye Collier-Thomas's *Jesus, Jobs, and Justice* (2010) make important distinctions between presenting the activism of Black women through the "everyday" acts of resistance to racism and sexism vs. celebrating the most notable of figures through the social and political institution of the Black church.
- Dayo Gore's *Radicalism at the Crossroads* (2011) occupies the secular realm, specifically the Radical Left, highlighting the ability for Black women activists to occupy spheres locally, nationally, and internationally as well as interracial spaces among non-Black leftist activists (particularly, White women activists).

The Settlement House Movement

- Judith Trolander's *Settlement Houses and the Great Depression* (1975) offers insightful perspective on the relationship between philanthropic influence and social reform as well as differing standards pertaining to race relations—particularly, through her analysis of Community Chest funds' impact on settlement houses' social reform activities.
- Elizabeth Lasch-Quinn's *Black Neighbors: Race and the Limits of Reform in the American Settlement House Movement, 1890-1945* (1993) is acutely critical of the mainstream settlement house movement, both in history and its scholarly retelling. It redefines its boundaries and scope to include the Black settlement house movement, specifically in the rural South.

Historical Research on Black Minnesota

- Abram L. Harris's *The Negro Population in Minneapolis: A Study of Race Relations* (1926?) provides primary-source metrics of Black Minnesota in the 1920's and proves W. Gertrude Brown's social capital among Black Minnesotans.
- Earl Spangler's *The Negro in Minnesota* (1961) undertakes the first comprehensive study of Minnesota Black history by major institutions in Minnesota's public sphere.
- David V. Taylor's *African Americans in Minnesota* (2002) offers accessible narratives of Black Minnesota through the vein of public history.

Phyllis Wheatley House & W. Gertrude Brown

- Howard Jacob Karger's "Phyllis Wheatley House: A History of the Minneapolis Black Settlement House, 1924 to 1940" (1986) and *The Sentinels of Order: A Study of Social Control and the Minneapolis Settlement House Movement, 1915-1950* (1987) focus on paternalism and social control and modes of analysis regarding the relationship between Phyllis Wheatley House and W. Gertrude Brown.
- Michiko Hase's dissertation "W. Gertrude Brown's struggle for racial justice: Female leadership and community in Black Minneapolis, 1920-1940" (1994) revises Karger's narrative by employing a Black feminist perspective in her analysis of the House and Brown, thereby redirecting agency to Brown in ways that stifled in past scholarship.

METHODOLOGY

- Libraries and online databases utilized for obtaining secondary source material and online records of historically-Black national periodicals during the early 20th century
- Archival research conducted in Social Welfare History Archives at the University of Minnesota and select collections at Minnesota Historical Society
- A critical case-study analysis of W. Gertrude Brown conceptualized through the synthesis of Black feminist thought, Black public sphere theory, and critical literature review of theoretical perspective

DISCUSSION

Cementing Phyllis Wheatley House as a Crucial Institution in Black Minnesota

- Created a space at the House where all Black residents and organizations could access resources and advance their causes
- Positioned the House as a vital voice of the Black community to the greater public
- Utilized her connections both locally and nationally to situate the House as destination point for prominent African-Americans during the era

Notable Strategies, Activities, and Networks of Black Women's Activism

- Maintained active membership in both Black and non-Black organizations and committees in her professional, civic, religious, and racial justice circles
- Embraced international in her professional career
- Frequently travelled and addressed numerous organizations
- Occupying multiple public spheres was crucial to her success



Gertrude Brown with children at Phyllis Wheatley House, 808 Bassett Place, Minneapolis.

FUTURE RESEARCH

- Centralizing studies on Black women of the 20th century
- Identifying other Black women agents of change whose primary careers span across sectors (e.g. education, government, etc.)
- Conducting original oral history interviews with the aim of conveying Black women's essential contributions to Minnesota's progressive politics